

MGT 449: Generative AI for Business

Professors Vincent R. Nijs and Thales Teixeira
Rady School of Management @ UCSD

Table of contents

1 Instructor Bios	2
1.1 Professor Vincent Nijs	2
1.2 Professor Thales S. Teixeira	3
2 Course Objectives	3
3 Tools	4
4 Course Materials	4
5 Grading Policy	4
6 Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) policy	5
7 Class Etiquette and Punctuality	5
8 Attendance	5
9 Work Sessions	6
10 Support	6
11 Project	6
11.1 Key Components	6
12 Modules	7

Instructor:

- Prof. Vincent R. Nijs (<mailto:vnijs@ucsd.edu>)
- Office: 3W116

- Office hours: By appointment

Teaching Assistants:

- TBD (mailto:tbd@ucsd.edu)

Tech and Programming TA:

- Liza Babior (mailto:lbabior@ucsd.edu)
- Office hours: TBD

CLASS ID

- MGT 449

Class Room

- TBD

Sessions

- Thursday: 2-5pm

1 Instructor Bios

1.1 Professor Vincent Nijs

Vincent Nijs is a Teaching Professor of Business Analytics and Marketing, and the co-founder and faculty director of the Master of Science in Business Analytics (MSBA) program at the Rady School of Management, UCSD. He holds a master's degree in marketing research from the University of Groningen in the Netherlands and a Ph.D. in marketing from the University of Leuven in Belgium. Professor Nijs' research interests include competitive actions and retaliation, inertia in decision making, and Generative AI.

Before joining Rady, Professor Nijs was an assistant professor of marketing at the Kellogg School of Management, Northwestern University. At Kellogg, he served as the McManus Research Professor and received the Sidney J. Levy Teaching Award for outstanding teaching in an elective course. At Rady, he has been awarded the Excellence in Teaching award from MBA and MSBA programs and the Most Valuable Professor award. In 2025 he was awarded the Distinguished Teaching Award for Academic Senate Members at UCSD.

1.2 Professor Thales S. Teixeira

Prof. Teixeira is the co-founder of digital disruption consultancy Decoupling.co. He was the Lumry Family Associate Professor at Harvard Business School, where he taught for 10 years. There he has taught MBA, doctoral and executive-level courses in Marketing Models, Digital Marketing and Ecommerce. His two primary domains of research constitute Digital Disruption (<https://www.decoupling.co/>) and The Economics of Attention (<https://www.economicsofattention.com>).

He is the author of dozens of articles published in trade press outlets such as The Harvard Business Review, The McKinsey Quarterly, Think with Google, and in academic journals such as Marketing Science, JMR, JM, and JAR. His research and opinions have been routinely featured in The NY Times, The Financial Times, ABC Nightly News, NBC News, NPR, Forbes, Quartz, The New Yorker and The Guardian.

He was formerly an expert reviewer for the US Food and Drug Administration under President Barack Obama. And he is one of the current judges of CNBC's Disruptor 50 most innovative startups. He has consulted or advised top executives of over 15 of the Fortune 100 companies.

2 Course Objectives

Generative AI (GenAI) is developing at an incredible speed. Companies are eager to adopt these new technologies but many struggle with implementation. In this course you will learn how to leverage GenAI in real business settings.

- **Business Impact:** GenAI is already transforming core business functions - from enhancing and automating business processes to supporting and enhancing data analysis. You'll learn which tools work best for different business problems and how to implement them effectively.
- **Practical Decision-Making:** You'll learn how to combine GenAI with existing business processes to improve decision-making. This includes knowing when to use AI and, importantly, when not to use it.
- **Workflow Improvement:** GenAI can streamline operations across departments. You'll learn to identify where these tools add real value and how to implement them in ways that actually work.
- **Career Development:** Understanding GenAI isn't optional anymore - it's becoming a core business skill. This course will give you hands-on experience with tools that companies are actively using and hiring for.

- **Broad Applications:** The skills you'll learn apply across business functions - from marketing and finance to operations and strategy. You'll work on real business processes to understand how these tools can solve problems. This is a practical course. You'll spend most of your time working with GenAI tools on real business problems. By the end, you'll be able to:
- Identify where GenAI can add value to business processes
- Design and implement practical GenAI solutions
- Make better-informed decisions about AI adoption
- Effectively communicate AI capabilities and limitations to stakeholders

3 Tools

Tools used in this class will include:

- Claude Code
- N8N
- OpenClaw
- VS Code
- ChatGPT
- GitHub Copilot

4 Course Materials

For this class you will work through a mix of videos, articles, assignments, guest lectures, and cases; no textbook is required. Lecture notes and additional materials will be available on the course website.

We focus on the practical use of Generative AI to create business value. To prepare for the course we encourage you to start integrating Generative AI into your personal and business activities to gain additional experience with these powerful and disruptive technologies.

5 Grading Policy

Grades for this course will be based on the following components:

- Group Project 50%
- Individual Assignments 20%
- Class participation 30%

- Completed TODOs on the course website, excluding assignments and cases, will be counted towards the class participation grade
- 15 points will be deducted if peer evaluations are not submitted

Assignments submitted after the due date cannot be accepted. All regrade requests should be submitted no more than two weeks after the grade was posted. TAs will not consider in-person regrade requests.

6 Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) policy

Use of Generative AI is expected and encouraged in this class. That said, we expect that you understand and can answer detailed questions about the work you submit as your own.

7 Class Etiquette and Punctuality

- Laptops will be used for in-class exercises. However, it is distracting to classmates to sit next to or behind someone while they browse the web, send emails, etc. Tablets may be used to take notes.
- Phones can be used to answer polling questions.
- Class will start on time. It is distracting to classmates and to the instructor when someone arrives late, has to get to their seat, and settle in while others are trying to engage with the class material. If you are absent or late more than once, your class participation grade may be affected.

8 Attendance

Learning to present your work and to evaluate and respond to the work conducted by others is an important part of this class. If you miss class, you will miss this learning opportunity, and there is not an easy way to “make it up.” As a result, you should make every effort to attend class. If you miss class or are late more than once, it will lower your class participation grade.

Note that UCSD provides exceptions for religious holidays, funeral attendance, and student or dependent hospitalization. If you must miss a class, please let us know in advance. You should do the readings, watch videos, prepare, turn in the assignments on time (late assignments will not be accepted), and arrange to get notes from a fellow student about what you missed in class.

9 Work Sessions

We will have work sessions each week on Monday afternoon. Although these sessions are optional, I highly recommend you come to ask questions, discuss class material, work on assignments, and on your group project, either alone or with your group, etc.

10 Support

For questions about the class, please post to the Piazza site linked below.

<https://piazza.com/ucsd/spring2026/mgt449>

- School: UCSD
- Term: Spring 2026
- Class: mgt449

When you post a question to Piazza, please make the post “public” whenever possible. It is fine if you prefer to be anonymous to your classmates. That is up to you. However, we will get the greatest value out of using Piazza if (most) posts are public.

11 Project

The group project will span the full quarter and is divided into multiple milestones to develop an *AI-coworker*. The AI-coworker should (partially) automate and enhance a business process. This process can be in any business area or can even combine multiple business functions (e.g., marketing, analytics, finance, operations, supply chain, consulting, etc. etc.).

11.1 Key Components

1. **Business Process Analysis:** Identify and document a real-world business process related to your career interests, analyzing inefficiencies and opportunities for improvement.
2. **GenAI Integration Strategy:** Develop a comprehensive plan for integrating generative AI to enhance the selected business process, clearly delineating human and AI responsibilities.
3. **Functional Prototype Development:** Create a working prototype that demonstrates core functionality and key GenAI capabilities.
4. **User Experience Design:** Design a user-friendly interface with explicit mechanisms for human oversight and feedback.

5. **Application Delivery:** Implement a prototype that demonstrates the complete workflow with integrated GenAI.

Note: No programming experience is required. With state-of-the-art GenAI tools plus instructor and TA support you can build (almost) anything you can envision.

12 Modules

Modules are (mostly) designed to support the group project, which is the main focus of the class. Topics will include:

- Using GenAI for data generation, collection, cleaning, and analysis
- AI-human interaction
- Prompt engineering and best practices for working with GenAI
- Retrieval augmented generation (RAG)
- Tool-use and MCP to connect GenAI to external data sources and tools
- Single and multi-agent systems
- AI-gateways (e.g., OpenClaw)

These topics will be covered in a way that supports the group project milestones, with lectures, exercises, readings, videos, and assignments designed to help you make progress on your project while learning the necessary skills to create business value with GenAI.